



Original Ship = Continuous Ship

This is not a story of a ship crashing into itself; it seems fairly clear that



Original Ship = Reconstructed Ship



Continuous Ship $\neq$ Reconstructed Ship

The problem, though, is that these three claims are inconsistent. This is due to the transitivity of identity: if $A=B$, and $B=C$, then $A=C$.

What's the best way out of this paradox?

One natural thought is that we should reject the claim that Original Ship is the same as Reconstructed Ship. On this view, if you find all of the parts that composed some thing, and put them back together, that is not enough to reconstitute the thing. Rather, on this view, material objects survive via a series of causal connections over time, perhaps with the requirement that only relatively small changes at one time are possible.

We might state this view of the conditions under which material objects continue to exist as follows:

The small changes view

X is the same material object as Y just in case X is causally connected to Y by a series of small physical changes over time.

Consider, for example, your body when you were 5 years old and your body now. Surely there is not much qualitative resemblance!. But if the small changes view is correct, the two material objects might still be numerically identical.











This is because these two moments in the life of your body are connected by many, many others. And from one moment to the next, one stage of your body is caused by the previous stage, and at each such step only small changes take place.

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